

Automate nearly any task with Tasker

To start things off, the most powerful tool for automation on Android is without doubt, Tasker. While it's not a free app (and costs a pretty hefty ₹345 on the Play Store) we think it's completely worth it. Nevertheless, if you want to see what Tasker is capable of, the developers offer a 7-day free trial on their website (<http://tasker.dinglich.net/download.html>). Download and install the app to get started. You might need to enable 'Unknown Sources' in your phone's settings to install .apk files. Wink wink :-)

Setting up Tasker involves configuring three components – Contexts, Actions and Tasks. A rule that encapsulates all these three is called a Tasker profile. A Context is the 'trigger' that sets off a task, i.e. it is the 'if' part which determines what starts your task. Common triggers can include an application (opening, closing an app), a time of the day, a state (headset plugged in, phone plugged in to charger, low battery levels) or an event like receiving an SMS or a phone call. After choosing a context, we choose an Action, which is basically any action that your phone is capable of, including opening an app, showing a notification, toggling the GPS, Wifi or Bluetooth radio or sending an SMS. Individual tasks can be grouped into actions, so one action, can perform multiple tasks.

Finding all this too hard to follow? Fear not, we'll walk you through an example and then give you some really cool ideas that you can try on your own. You'll find that nearly any logical automation task can be performed by Tasker with ease, you're limited only by your imagination!

As an example, let's say that you want your phone to start your music player or music streaming app whenever you plug in your earphones.

1. Start the app and create a new profile. Give it a name.
2. For your first context, choose 'State', and 'Hardware' under State Category. Select 'Headset' from the hardware menu.
3. Now we need to define an action. Since we're launching our music player, we'll go with the 'App' option under Action Category. Select 'Load App' and choose the app you want to load.
4. That's about it! Tap the green check-



Edit each task to trigger actions

mark to activate the profile, and exit the app. You should now see a small lightning-shaped icon in your notification area telling you that Tasker is running in the background. Plug in your earphones and be amazed!

Now that you're familiar with Tasker, here are some tasks to try out:

1. Turn on your GPS whenever you open Google Maps (Only works for stock Android 2.2 or lesser, or custom ROMs)
2. Silence your phone when you place it face down on a table.
3. Make your phone play a random song from your music library as a morning alarm, or load your to-do list first thing in the morning.
4. Turn down your display's brightness / turn off mobile data at night and automatically turn it on in the morning.
5. Locate your phone using an SMS. You can send an SMS to your phone with a preset string like 'GPS ON'. After the GPS has been turned on, you can make your phone send you timely updates of its location.
6. Remind you via SMS or a reminder whenever it's your friend's birthday. (or any other event on Google Calendar)
7. Auto-respond to calls or SMSs when you're driving (i.e. when the phone is docked) or when you're asleep.
8. Display the missed call/unread SMS/unread email count on your homescreen/lock screen using an app like Minimalistic Text.
9. Unlock your phone whenever it connects to your home Wi-Fi network.
10. Perform a full Nandroid backup of

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